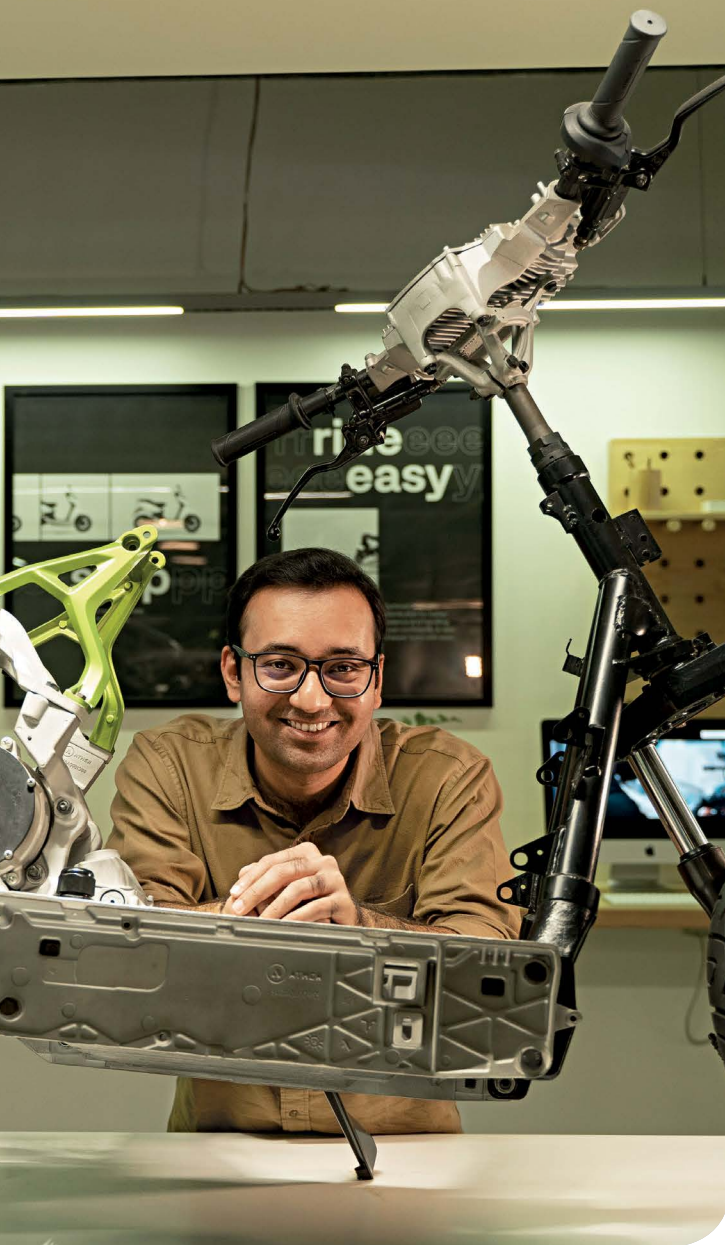




PHOTOS BY **SANDESH RAVIKUMAR**

as well as us as a company. So, I love competition.

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The Government of India has been big on EVs and with the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of (Hybrid &) Electric Vehicles (FAME) subsidy. But most EV companies have been accused of cutting corners to be a part of the scheme. How do you respond to that?

EV companies cutting corners to get in on the

FAME scheme is something [those who sell] entry-level scooters—who import most of them from China—are doing. At Ather, we make the base of our scooters here and we started [doing it] long back. People weren't even making smart-phones in the country when we decided to make touch-screen dashboards for the scooter. All that you see is designed and built in India and it is customised. The only thing we import are [lithium-

ion cells]; but that also we would stop and start manufacturing our own cells with the help of the government's push for this [in this year's Union Budget, the government exempted capital goods and machinery necessary to manufacture lithium-ion cells from paying import duty]. So, we are bringing [to life] India's *Aatmanirbhar* vision. We have 10,000 jobs in the manufacturing sector, and about 60-70 patents that have been filed. Our

with the vehicle just did not make sense. So, we started giving it as an option. A customer can buy a charger or a couple of chargers but we suggest that if you are upgrading your Ather even then you don't need to get a new one. The chargers are forward and backward compatible. The cost of a charger doesn't have to be a part of the cost of the vehicle, especially with Ather that has an accessible fast-charging grid. Hence, it was a conscious decision.

“ATHER WILL... EITHER BE THE NO. 1 OR NO. 2 TWO-WHEELER MAKER IN THE WORLD. WE ARE SETTING A TARGET OF \$1 BILLION IN REVENUES FOR THIS YEAR”

| **83**

R&D is the biggest [in the space] so at no point are we cutting corners. Automotive as an industry needs R&D and that takes time and money.

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Why is Ather not selling chargers along with its scooters?

Initially, we did sell them as one unit. But then we saw a pattern that showed that most people were buying their second or third scooter, so selling them a charger forcefully

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What's on the agenda now with production and sales?

We have managed to scale up production to 35,000 units a month but the supply chain is still scaling up with an average of 15,000-16,000 units a month. However, I am confident that with this [Hosur] plant, we will be functioning at full capacity by the end of this year as the supply chain stream clears up. We will be manufacturing 25,000-